Forecasting a journal's time to acceptance under cohort shift: a calibrated, strictly out-of-time method evaluated on 774 journals

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Abstract

Background: Authors and evaluators use a journal's recent time to acceptance to predict the wait for a new paper, but such forecasts and 'within X days' claims are rarely scored against later outcomes, and the simplest forecast is over-confident.

Methods: We used publisher-deposited received and accepted dates for 1,737,272 articles in 800 Springer Nature, Wiley and Taylor & Francis journals. At quarterly origins, forecasts used only papers visible at the origin, and every parameter learned from earlier data used only cohorts whose outcomes were complete at the origin. We propose CV0, which smooths a journal's last 12 months of durations with a Gaussian kernel whose variance is the cohort-to-cohort shift variance estimated from earlier cohorts, and compared it with empirical quantiles, constant width inflation, quantile recalibration and adaptive conformal updating over six origins (4,486 journal-origins, 482,065 papers). Hypotheses were fixed beforehand; one design flaw (the duration cap) was corrected by a disclosed amendment. A frozen version was tested on 117 external PubMed journals.

Results: Journal history lowered forecast loss by 15.7% relative to publisher-pooled forecasts, but empirical 80% intervals covered 1.9 points less than nominal, and the apparent shortfall depended on how slow papers were truncated (+2.2 to −2.4 points across caps of 270 days to none). CV0 moved coverage to +0.5 points, lowered mean absolute coverage error from 7.2 to 6.8 points (sampling-noise floor 3.6), slightly lowered pinball loss and interval score, and beat width inflation, recalibration and adaptive updating (imprint-level intervals just clear zero). The shortfall predicted for each journal from earlier cohorts correlated weakly with the observed one ($r = 0.15$) and overstated it. On external journals CV0 reduced absolute coverage error against empirical quantiles (6.9 vs 7.4 points) but not clearly against width inflation. Calibration slopes for the 72-day event rose from 0.89 to 0.92.

Conclusions: A journal's recent history is a useful forecast whose intervals should be widened for cohort shift; estimating it from earlier complete cohorts is a small but consistent improvement. Evaluations must handle truncation of slow papers explicitly. An open-source package and a browser tool implement the method.

Keywords: peer review; time to acceptance; probabilistic forecasting; calibration; distribution shift; conformal prediction; editorial process

Background

Journals advertise speed, and authors, funders and evaluators use a journal's past time to acceptance, usually a median or the share of papers accepted within a limit, to set expectations for the next paper. Reporting of such statistics is inconsistent and seldom accompanied by uncertainty [1, 2, 3], and aggregator pages already offer planning tools built on historical medians [4]. Whether a journal's own recent history is a calibrated forecast of the next paper, and how to correct it if not, is not settled by descriptive work on publication delay [5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13]. A registered plan for a PubMed-wide model of acceptance lag with a random training/test split exists [14]; its registration states that it was not preregistered, it was evaluated at MetaROR in April 2026, and we found no results in October 2026.

The statistical problem is forecasting under distribution shift with delayed outcomes. At the time of forecast, the papers that have been accepted are a biased sample (slow papers are not yet accepted), and papers submitted next may differ from those accepted recently in volume, mix and editorial practice. Conformal methods give distribution-free coverage under exchangeability, and extensions handle shift by weighting or by adaptively updating the miscoverage level [15, 16, 17]; they presuppose that coverage feedback is available, whereas here an outcome becomes known only after the paper is accepted, up to a year later.

We ask (RQ1) how much a journal's own history improves on pooled forecasts; (RQ2) how calibrated the simple empirical forecast is under a strictly out-of-time protocol, and how sensitive that conclusion is to the treatment of slow papers; (RQ3) whether a forecaster that estimates the cohort-to-cohort shift from earlier complete cohorts is better calibrated than empirical quantiles and than three standard corrections; (RQ4) whether the method transfers to journals of other publishers; and (RQ5) how reliable event probabilities such as 'accepted within 72 days' are. The study is empirical and makes no causal claims.

Methods

Data

Received and accepted dates are deposited in Crossref by Springer Nature, Wiley and Taylor & Francis. For each publisher we took the 1,000 ISSNs with most articles in 2023, merged print and online ISSNs and kept journals in which at least 80% of 40 random 2023 records carried both dates and the number of dated 2023 articles was 150–3,000 (802 entries, 800 distinct journals). All records published from 1 January 2021 to 20 October 2026 were downloaded. The estimand is D, days from received to accepted, conditional on acceptance. After cleaning (duplicate DOIs, $D < 1$ or $> 1{,}460$ days, acceptance more than seven days after first online publication, non-research items by title or fewer than five references),

1,737,272 of 1,829,907 records remained; median D was 124 days. Journals were assigned to an imprint by the modal DOI prefix. External data were PubMed History received and accepted dates of 127 journals of other publishers (Elsevier, Cell Press, Oxford and Cambridge University Presses, PLOS and society journals; none from Springer Nature, Wiley, Taylor & Francis or MDPI), selected by a journal list fixed in the collection script before any records were fetched, and kept if at least 600 dated records were returned (121 journals; 310,288 clean records). PubMed entry date served as the first-online date.

Forecasting protocol and the strict out-of-time rule

Origins are quarterly. At an origin t0 the visible set of a journal is its papers first online within the preceding 12 months and already received and accepted before t0. The target is the set of papers received in the following 91 days. A journal-origin is evaluated with at least 100 visible and 30 target papers. Durations are capped at 480 days for training and scoring (see Results for why the cap matters). A method at origin t0 may use for learning only earlier origins o whose targets were complete at t0, that is o + 91 + 480 days ≤ t0; with the data ending on 20 October 2026 the evaluation origins are 1 October 2023 to 1 January 2025 (six origins, with one to six earlier complete origins). This rule prevents information about outcomes that would not yet have been known from reaching any forecast. The first Part D run used a 365-day cap and nine origins; it is reported alongside (see Order of events).

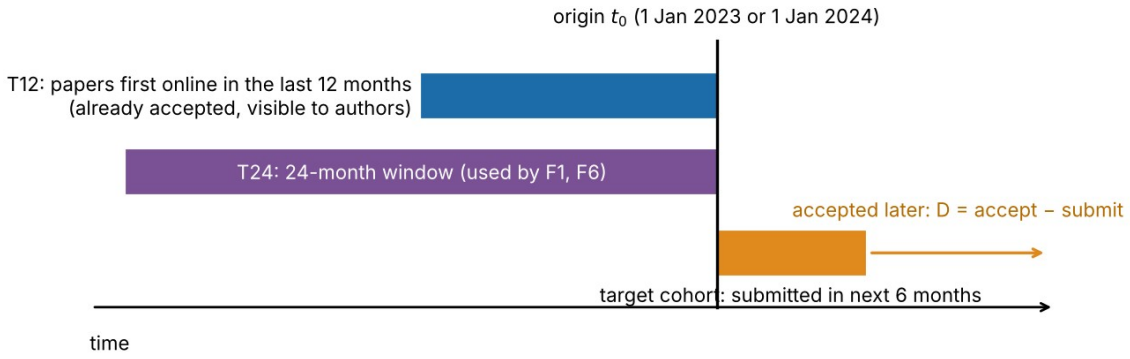


Figure 1. Conceptual schematic (not data) of the out-of-time protocol: forecasts use only the visible training set at the origin and are scored against papers received afterwards; parameters use only earlier cohorts whose outcomes are complete.

Forecasters

All forecasts are for the 0.1, …, 0.9 quantiles of ln D. F0: empirical quantiles of the visible 12-month sample (Hazen definition [18]). F6: exponentially time-decayed quantiles (half-life 182.5 days). V: half-widths about the median multiplied by one constant (grid 1.000 to 1.400 in steps of 0.025) that gives 80% pooled coverage on earlier complete origins. R: F0 with quantile levels replaced through the empirical

distribution of probability-integral-transform values on earlier complete origins. ACI: adaptive update of the miscoverage level of the F0 80% interval, $\alpha \leftarrow \alpha + \gamma(0.20 - m)$, with $\gamma = 0.05$ and m the pooled miscoverage on each earlier complete origin in time order [15]; it yields an interval only. F2, publisher-pooled quantiles that ignore journal identity, is a deliberately weak baseline used to measure the value of journal information.

CV0 (proposed). Let $y_1, \ldots, y_n$ be the visible ln-durations, s^2 their variance. The predictive distribution is $G(q) = (1/n) \Sigma \Phi((q - y_i)/h)$ with $h^2 = \tau^2 + s^2/n$; quantiles are found by bisection. The term s^2/n is the sampling variance of the journal's location; τ^2 is the variance of the location shift between the visible sample and the next cohort. τ^2 is estimated per publisher from earlier complete origins by the method of moments, $\hat{\tau}^2 = \max(0, \mathrm{Var}_j(\Delta_j) - \mathrm{mean}_j(s^2_{tr}/n_{tr} + s^2_{te}/n_{te}))$, where Δ_j is the difference between the mean ln-duration of the realised target cohort and of the visible sample of journal-origin j. CV0 is thus the empirical forecast convolved with a normal location shift. Variants: CVb adds the publisher-mean shift of Δ to the visible sample; CVg uses one $\hat{\tau}^2$ for all publishers.

Metrics, hypotheses and inference

Primary metrics: (a) the journal-mean absolute error of 80% interval coverage, |coverage − 0.80|; (b) mean pinball loss over nine quantile levels [19, 20]; (c) the mean 80% interval score [21]. Because a journal-origin has 30 or more target papers, the absolute coverage error has an irreducible sampling component; under perfect calibration its expectation, computed from each journal's target sizes, is 3.6 points, and we report errors relative to it. Hypotheses fixed before the run: HD1, CV0 has lower absolute coverage error than F0; HD2, CV0's pinball loss is not more than 0.5% above F0's; HD3, CV0's pooled signed coverage lies within ±1.5 points of 80%; HD4, CV0 has lower absolute coverage error than each of V, R and ACI (Holm adjusted); HD5, the shortfall predicted for each journal-origin from CV0's distribution with earlier-cohort $\hat{\tau}^2$, $G(q90_F0) - G(q10_F0) - 0.80$, correlates positively with the observed shortfall across journals; HD6, with parameters frozen from the frame, CV0 has lower absolute coverage error than F0 and V on external journals. Uncertainty used journal-cluster bootstraps (3,000 draws, journal averaged first), t intervals with 6 degrees of freedom on the means of the seven imprints, publisher-level sign checks, and a moving-block bootstrap (block length 2) over the ordered origins [22, 23].

Order of events and amendments

The cycle-3 protocol (Part D), the external journal list and the code were committed to the project's git history before any Part D result existed; this is a pre-specification by the analyst, not a registered report. Two programming errors and one arithmetic slip stopped runs before any output and were corrected. After the first complete run (cap 365 days; nine origins), the pre-specified HD5 failed and CV0 over-covered by 1.2 points. An exploratory sensitivity analysis then showed that F0's shortfall depends on the cap, because

a capped value lies inside the interval of any journal whose upper quantile reaches the cap, so a short cap inflates coverage. The analysis was therefore repeated with a 480-day cap (amendment D-A2, committed before any cap-480 result), which is the primary analysis here; the cap-365 results are reported alongside. The choice of 480 days was made from the cap sensitivity of F0 alone. Earlier cycles of this project are documented in the repository; their results on dependence, article-level covariates and drift are not repeated here.

Use of AI

The analysis code, the package and drafts of this manuscript were produced with an AI system (Claude, Anthropic) acting as an autonomous research assistant in a sandboxed environment; separately launched instances of the same model family performed adversarial reviews, a prior-art search and reproducibility audits. No human expert has reviewed the work.

Results

Journal history has value, and the shortfall of empirical intervals (RQ1, RQ2)

Between-journal differences explained 26.5% of the variance of ln D (95% CI 24.7%–28.3%); 69.1% lay between articles within a journal. On the two original origins (1,531 journal-origins, 781 journals, 298,469 target papers; 182-day targets), journal-specific empirical forecasts lowered pinball loss by 15.7% relative to publisher-pooled forecasts, and their 80% intervals covered 77.0% of later papers (journal average), −3.0 points from nominal. In the strict six-origin analysis (774 journals, 4,486 journal-origins, 482,065 papers) F0 gave −1.9 points (journal-cluster CI −2.3 to −1.5); by origin the shortfall ranged from −1.3 to −2.5 points and was negative in all three publishers.

The size of the shortfall depended strongly on the treatment of slow papers (Figure 2a). At origins where every setting had complete targets, F0's signed coverage error with 91-day targets was +2.2 points with a 270-day cap, −0.9 with 365, −2.0 with 480 and −2.4 with no cap, whereas 182-day target cohorts gave the same values within 0.2 points. A cap sets slow papers to the cap value, which lies inside the interval of every journal whose upper quantile reaches it. Evaluations of turnaround forecasts on capped or censored durations can therefore overstate calibration; we use a 480-day cap, where the bias relative to no cap is +0.4 points, and report cap-365 results as a sensitivity.

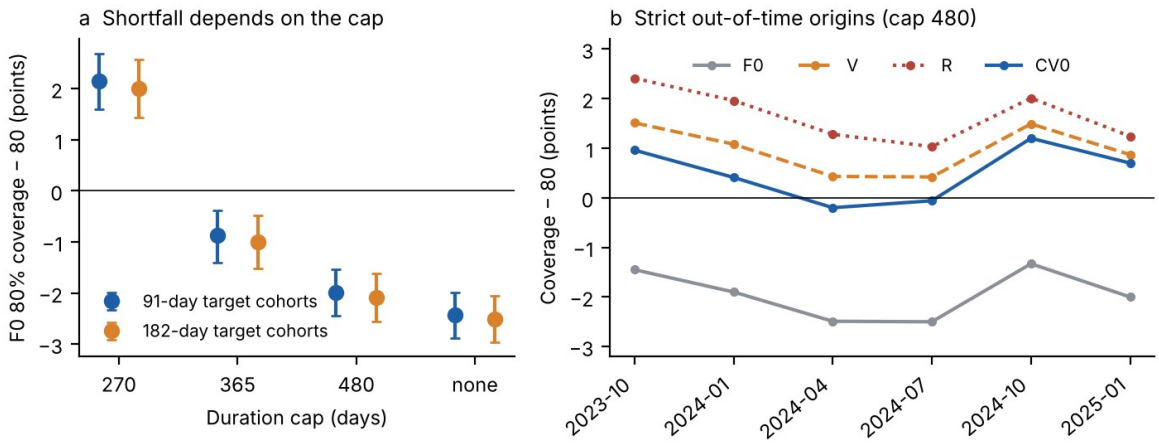


Figure 2. (a) Coverage error of the empirical 80% interval (F0) as a function of the duration cap, for 91- and 182-day target cohorts (exploratory analysis, origins 2023-07 to 2024-07; journal-cluster 95% CIs). (b) Signed coverage error by origin for F0, constant width inflation (V), quantile recalibration (R) and the proposed CV0 in the primary strict analysis.

A cohort-shift forecaster improves calibration modestly (RQ3)

Table 1. Strict out-of-time evaluation, cap 480 days (6 origins, 774 journals, 4,486 journal-origins, 482,065 papers). The sampling-noise floor of the absolute error is 3.6 points.

Forecaster	Signed coverage − 80 (points) [CI]	Mean |coverage − 80| (points) [CI]	Pinball loss	Interval score	Width (ln-days)
F0 empirical	−1.9 [−2.3, −1.5]	7.18 [6.88, 7.49]	0.2026	2.409	1.58
F6 time-decayed	−1.5 [−1.9, −1.1]	6.96 [6.68, 7.25]	0.2019	2.398	1.59
V width inflation	+1.0 [+0.6, +1.4]	7.05 [6.79, 7.32]	0.2027	2.413	1.70
R recalibration	+1.7 [+1.3, +2.1]	7.03 [6.79, 7.28]	0.2024	2.400	1.70
ACI adaptive α	−1.5 [−1.9, −1.0]	7.11 [6.82, 7.42]	–	2.409	1.60
CV0 (proposed)	+0.5 [+0.1, +0.9]	6.75 [6.51, 7.02]	0.2024	2.403	1.68
CVb (CV0 + mean shift)	+1.0 [+0.6, +1.4]	6.71 [6.48, 6.97]	0.2022	2.400	1.68

CV0 moved signed coverage from −1.9 to +0.5 points (CI +0.1 to +0.9), within the ±1.5 points of HD3, and reduced the mean absolute coverage error from 7.18 to 6.75 points, a difference of −0.42 points (journal-cluster CI −0.54 to −0.30; imprint-level t(6) CI −0.70 to −0.02; negative in 3 of 3 publishers and 6 of 7 imprints; moving-block CI over origins −0.57 to −0.28) (HD1). Relative to the sampling-noise floor, CV0 removed 12% of F0's excess error. This is a modest gain, because most of the per-journal error is binomial noise from 30 to a few hundred target papers; its value is mainly in removing the systematic under-coverage. Pinball loss did not increase (lower by 0.0003 ln-days, −0.14%; CI −0.15% to −0.09%) and the interval score fell by 0.007 (CI -0.009 to -0.004) (HD2).

Table 2. Contrasts of CV0 with the comparators on absolute coverage error (negative favours CV0). Journal-level p values treat journals as independent and are optimistic; the imprint-level intervals are the more conservative statement.

Contrast in mean | coverage − 80| (points)	Difference [journal-cluster 95% CI]	Imprint t(6) 95% CI	Publishers with same sign	Holm p (journal level)
CV0 − V width inflation	−0.30 [−0.39, −0.21]	[−0.45, −0.12]	3/3	2.9e-11
CV0 − R recalibration	−0.28 [−0.38, −0.17]	[−0.47, −0.13]	3/3	2.8e-07
CV0 − ACI adaptive α	−0.36 [−0.47, −0.26]	[−0.58, −0.07]	3/3	8.0e-11
CV0 − F0	−0.42 [−0.54, −0.30]	[−0.70, −0.02]	3/3	–

CV0 had lower absolute coverage error than width inflation, recalibration and adaptive conformal updating (HD4; Table 2). The differences are about 0.3 points. Two features distinguish CV0 from the comparators. V and R apply one pooled correction to all journals, while CV0 adjusts each journal's width by its own sampling variance as well as by the learned shift; and ACI uses one global level that moved little because pooled coverage on the earlier origins was close to nominal (α stayed at 0.193). The mean-shift variant CVb had similar absolute error (6.71) and the lowest Brier scores (below). The fitted $\hat{\tau}^2$ were 0.041 (Springer Nature), 0.038 (Wiley) and 0.041 (Taylor & Francis) log-days squared when learned from all complete cohorts, so a typical cohort mean moves by about 0.20 ln-units (roughly 22%) between the visible sample and the next cohort.

Does the mechanism hold? (HD5)

The shortfall that CV0's own distribution predicts for F0, computed with $\hat{\tau}^2$ from earlier complete cohorts only (so not circular), correlated with the observed shortfall across journals (r = 0.15, journal-cluster CI 0.03 to 0.26; Spearman 0.20), and the observed-on-predicted slope was 0.46 (CI 0.09 to 0.94; Figure 3a). The prediction was directionally right but too large (mean predicted −3.2 vs observed −1.9 points), so the model overstates the shift variance that matters for coverage, and the relation is weak. In the first run with a 365-day cap the same pre-specified test failed (r = -0.12). We therefore regard the mechanism as supported weakly and conditionally on the cap, not established.

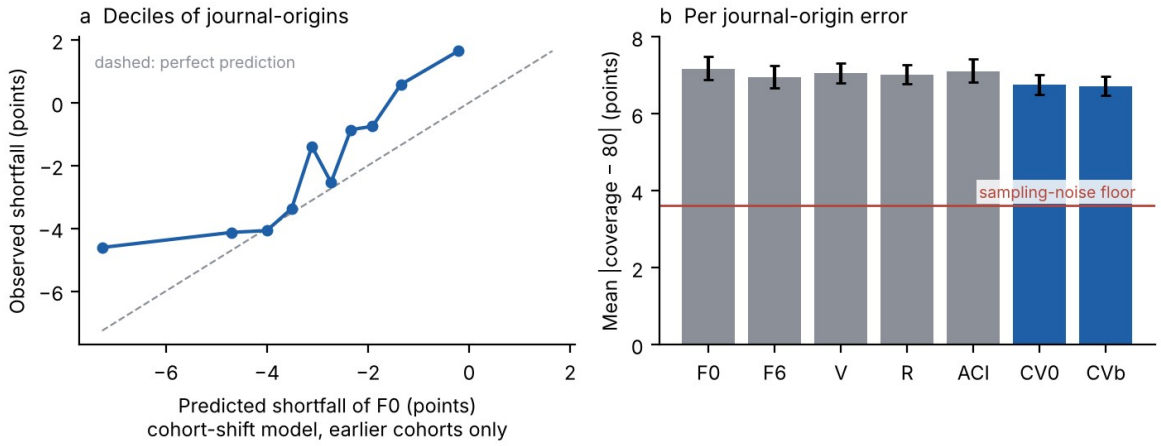


Figure 3. (a) Observed against predicted shortfall of F0, by decile of journal-origins (predictions use only earlier complete cohorts). (b) Mean absolute coverage error by forecaster with journal-cluster 95% CIs; the line is the expected error under perfect calibration given the target sizes.

Event probabilities and 'within X days' claims (RQ5)

Table 3. Brier score and calibration slope (observed share on forecast probability; 1 is perfect) of event probabilities, journal-origins as in Table 1.

Event D ≤ T	F0: Brier / slope	CV0: Brier / slope	CVb: Brier / slope
72 days	0.00915 / 0.89	0.00900 / 0.92	0.00853 / 0.94
120 days	0.01384 / 0.91	0.01330 / 0.96	0.01305 / 0.96
180 days	0.01285 / 0.90	0.01217 / 0.94	0.01229 / 0.92

Empirical probabilities of acceptance within 72, 120 and 180 days were too extreme (slope 0.89, 0.91 and 0.90); CV0 lowered the Brier scores and moved the slopes towards one (Table 3), and CVb did so further for the shorter horizons. On the original origins, 12.0% of 1,531 journal-origins accepted at least half of their papers within 72 days and 1.6% at least 80% (journal-cluster CIs 9.9%–14.2% and 0.9%–2.4%); the shares fell to 9–12% after excluding fast-lane journals, batch acceptances and low-reference articles, so a claim that a journal accepts most papers within 72 days describes a minority of journals.

External validation (RQ4)

Table 4. External journals (117 journals, 652 journal-origins, 74,787 papers) with parameters frozen from the frame.

Forecaster	Signed coverage − 80 (points) [CI]	Mean |coverage − 80| (points) [CI]	Pinball loss	Interval score
F0 empirical	−2.0 [−3.3, −0.8]	7.40 [6.44, 8.54]	0.2108	2.526
F6 time-decayed	−1.6 [−2.9, −0.5]	7.05 [6.15, 8.14]	0.2101	2.518
V width inflation (frame c)	+1.0 [−0.3, +2.1]	7.14 [6.25, 8.19]	0.2109	2.533
CV0 (frame τ^2, global)	+1.1 [−0.1, +2.2]	6.90 [6.05, 7.90]	0.2105	2.519
CVb (frame τ^2, mean shift)	+1.3 [+0.2, +2.4]	6.91 [6.10, 7.86]	0.2104	2.516

On 117 journals of publishers outside the frame (652 journal-origins, 74,787 papers), F0 under-covered by 2.0 points (CI −3.3 to −0.8 on the signed scale), close to the 1.9 points in the frame. With the frame's pooled $\hat{\tau}^2$ applied unchanged, CV0 had lower absolute coverage error than F0 (−0.50 points; CI −0.91 to −0.11) and slightly lower pinball loss (difference -0.00025; CI -0.00044 to -0.00008), but its difference from width inflation with the frame's constant was −0.25 points (CI −0.51 to 0.03), compatible with zero. HD6, which required superiority over both F0 and V, is therefore supported against F0 and not against V. The signed coverage of CV0 and V was +1.1 and +1.0 points; Brier scores for the 72-day event improved (0.01105 to 0.01088; slope 0.87 to 0.90). The external set is a non-random list of high-volume journals,

the first-online date is a PubMed entry-date proxy, and with six origins and 652 journal-origins the intervals are wide.

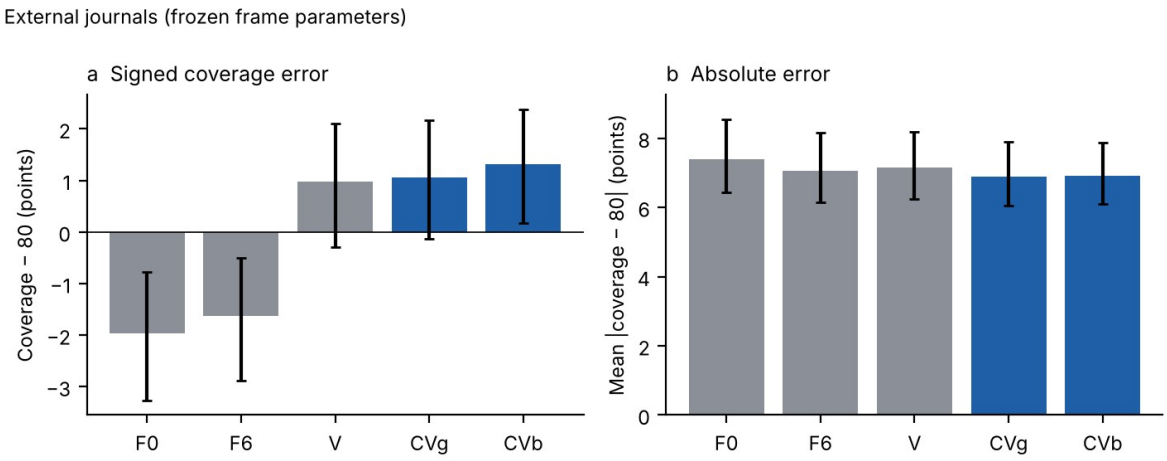


Figure 4. External validation: signed (a) and absolute (b) coverage error with frozen frame parameters; journal-cluster 95% CIs.

The first complete run (cap 365 days)

Table 5. Pre-specified hypotheses and outcomes in the primary analysis and in the first complete run.

Hypothesis	Primary: cap 480, six origins	As first run: cap 365, nine origins
HD1 CV0 lower absolute error than F0	−0.42 [−0.54, −0.30]: supported	−0.37 [−0.47, −0.26]: supported
HD2 pinball not > 0.5% above F0	−0.14%, upper CI −0.09%: supported	−0.11%, upper CI −0.01%: supported
HD3 signed coverage within ±1.5 points	+0.5 [+0.1, +0.9]: supported	+1.2 [+0.8, +1.6]: point estimate within, CI upper bound beyond
HD4 lower error than V, R, ACI	all three supported	all three supported
HD5 predicted vs observed shortfall, positive	r = 0.15: weakly supported	r = -0.12: not supported
HD6 external: lower error than F0 and V	vs F0 supported; vs V −0.25 [−0.51, 0.03]: not supported	not run at cap 365

Validity of the received date

Of 4,018 Springer Nature articles with a Research Square preprint, 95% were received no later than 14 days after the preprint was posted (journal-weighted 82%) and 2.6% more than 90 days after. The pre-set criterion of 70% within ±14 days was not met (47%), because these preprints are posted about two weeks after receipt; the other two statistics are post hoc and show compatibility, not confirmation, with the received date being the original submission date, within a resolution of 14 days. For Wiley and Taylor & Francis the probe is uninformative.

Software

The method is implemented in an open-source Python package (turnaround_forecast) with command-line interface and tests, including a test that reproduces the pipeline's CV0 quantiles for more than 20 journal-

origins, and in a self-contained browser tool that runs the same formulas locally and checks 'accepted within X days' claims against the forecast. The shipped $\hat{\tau}^2$ (0.040 log-days squared) was learned from all quarterly cohorts from 2022-01 to 2025-01, whose outcomes are complete.

Discussion

A journal's own last year of papers is a useful forecast of its next papers, worth about 16% of loss over ignoring journal identity within a publisher, but its 80% intervals are too narrow by about two points of coverage once slow papers are handled properly, and its event probabilities are too extreme. Widening the forecast by the cohort-to-cohort shift variance estimated from earlier complete cohorts corrects the average bias, keeps sharpness and improves Brier scores. The improvement over simpler corrections is small, about 0.3 points of absolute coverage error against a noise floor of 3.6 points, and on external journals it is not distinguishable from constant width inflation. We think the practical message is less 'use CV0' than 'a journal's turnaround distribution must be widened for cohort shift, and the widening can be learned from the journal's peers using only information that is complete at the time'.

Two methodological points have wider use. First, evaluations that cap or censor slow papers can show calibrated intervals where the uncensored intervals are not, because capped values fall inside any interval whose upper quantile reaches the cap; our cap sensitivity moves the same forecaster's apparent coverage by more than four points. Second, parameters that correct coverage must be learned from cohorts whose outcomes are complete at the origin; a first-pass recalibration in an earlier cycle of this project that used cohorts not yet complete looked better than it was. Conformal updating with delayed feedback is a natural extension we did not tune: with a single global level it barely moved the pooled coverage.

For authors and evaluators, statements of the form 'X% of papers are accepted within T days' should give the cohort (accepted or submitted), the period, the treatment of article types with fast lanes and an uncertainty interval; the browser tool shows how far such a claim moves when the forecast is calibrated. The results concern published, accepted papers and say nothing about the probability that a submission is accepted.

Limitations

- Conditioning on acceptance: only accepted papers have dates; rejected and withdrawn submissions are unobserved.

- Date semantics: received dates are publisher-defined and validated only for Springer Nature journals through Research Square preprints; the external journals use PubMed History dates and an entry-date proxy for first-online date.
- Frame and effect size: three publishers (the highest-level clusters), journals with about 150–3,000 dated articles per year; the external set is a non-random list of high-volume journals. The improvement of CV0 over simpler corrections is small and, on external journals, not distinguishable from width inflation; the mechanism test (HD5) is weakly supported at cap 480 and failed at cap 365, and the model overstates the size of the shortfall.
- Design history: the primary analysis follows an amendment made after the first full run, motivated by the cap sensitivity of F0 alone; the earlier run and amendment are reported. Parameters were learned from one to six earlier cohorts at the evaluation origins; $\hat{\tau}^2$ estimated from more cohorts may differ. A duration cap of 480 days still biases coverage slightly relative to no cap.
- Inference: journal-cluster intervals treat journals as independent and are optimistic; the imprint-level intervals use seven clusters and a t distribution, and publisher-level checks use three. Origins overlap in information.
- Process: the whole study was carried out by AI instances with automated reviews and audits and no human review; novelty is stated as 'we found no' because the literature search was not systematic.
- Scope: the study concerns editorial-process statistics, not peer review itself.

Conclusions

A journal's recent acceptance times are a useful but over-confident forecast of its next papers. Estimating the cohort-to-cohort shift from earlier complete cohorts and widening the forecast accordingly improves calibration modestly and consistently in a strictly out-of-time evaluation and transfers to external journals against empirical quantiles, though not clearly against constant width inflation. Evaluations of turnaround forecasts should treat slow papers explicitly, and turnaround statistics should be reported as quantiles for explicit cohorts with uncertainty.

Abbreviations

CV0, cohort-shift smoothed empirical forecaster; F0–F6, V, R, ACI, comparator forecasters defined in Methods; D, days from received to accepted; CI, confidence interval.

Declarations

Ethics approval and consent to participate: not applicable; the study analyses public article metadata.

Consent for publication: not applicable.

Availability of data and materials: raw Crossref and PubMed records, processing code, configuration, the package and all results are in the project repository (https://github.com/Bhargavteja-9779/rp_c_8, branch claude/autonomous-research-institute-nz8co5), which is not yet archived with a persistent identifier; a DOI-bearing deposit (for example Zenodo) must be created before submission. Live API data change over time; SHA-256 hashes of the cleaned frame files are in results/data_manifest.json.

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Authors' information: [to be completed].

Use of AI: described in Methods.

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Note: journal titles are not abbreviated according to Index Medicus because the style guide could not be applied automatically; the authors should abbreviate them.